# ShopEase Seller & Marketplace Policy Knowledge Base (KB)

**Document Owner:** Seller Success & Marketplace Trust Team

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## 1. How Third-Party Sellers Work on ShopEase

### 1.1 The Marketplace Model

ShopEase operates as an online marketplace. While some products are sold directly by ShopEase Retail, the vast majority are sold by independent, third-party businesses. ShopEase acts as the facilitator (intermediary) connecting buyers with these sellers, providing the platform, payment gateway, and often the logistics.

### 1.2 Fulfillment Models

- **Fulfilled by ShopEase (FBE):** The seller stores their inventory in ShopEase warehouses. ShopEase handles picking, packing, shipping, and customer service for returns.
- **Seller-Fulfilled (SF):** The seller keeps the inventory at their own premises. When an order is placed, the seller packs the item, and a ShopEase logistics partner (or a third-party courier) picks it up for delivery.

### 1.3 Legal Disclaimer (Agent Scripting)

*Agents must clarify to customers:* "ShopEase provides the platform for independent sellers. The contract of sale is strictly between you and the seller. However, ShopEase protects your purchase under the ShopEase Buyer Protection Guarantee."

## 2. Seller Ratings and Accountability

### 2.1 Seller Rating System

Sellers are rated on a 5-star scale based on customer feedback, product quality, shipping speed (for SF orders), and cancellation rates.

### 2.2 Accountability & Penalties

- **Performance Metrics:** Sellers must maintain a minimum rating of 3.5 stars.
- **High Returns:** If a seller's Return Rate exceeds 15% in a specific category, their listings will be temporarily suppressed from search results.
- **Auto-Delisting:** Sellers whose ratings drop below 2.5 stars for two consecutive months are automatically suspended from the platform.

### 2.3 Agent Action

When a customer complains about a poor experience that doesn't violate a specific policy, agents should encourage the customer to leave a factual Seller Review, as this directly impacts the seller's visibility and platform privileges.

## 3. Reporting a Fraudulent Seller

### 3.1 Scenario Definition

A customer alleges that a seller is intentionally defrauding buyers (e.g., sending empty boxes, sending bricks/stones instead of electronics, collecting data outside the platform).

### 3.2 Policy Guidelines

- **Immediate Escalation:** Fraud reports bypass standard Tier 1 troubleshooting and go directly to the Trust & Safety (T&S) team.
- **SLA for Action:** T&S must review the seller's account within 24 business hours.

### 3.3 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Gather Evidence:** Request unboxing videos, photos of the package weight/shipping label, and the contents received.
2. **Log the Incident:** Create a high-priority ticket under the category Marketplace Trust > Fraudulent Seller.
3. **Freeze Payouts:** Initiate an automated hold on the seller's pending payouts via the OMS (Order Management System) to protect buyer funds.
4. **Resolution to Buyer:** If evidence heavily supports the buyer (or if multiple buyers report the same seller simultaneously), issue an immediate 100% refund without waiting for a reverse pickup.
5. **Seller Ban:** T&S will permanently ban the seller and blacklist their GSTIN and bank details.

## 4. Counterfeit Product Complaints

### 4.1 Scenario Definition

A customer claims the product received is a knock-off, replica, or fake version of a branded item.

### 4.2 Policy Guidelines

ShopEase maintains a "Zero Tolerance" policy for counterfeit goods. Sellers found violating this are subject to immediate account termination and potential legal action.

### 4.3 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Request Details:** Ask the customer for specific photos showing why the item is counterfeit (e.g., missing holograms, spelling errors on packaging, poor build quality).
2. **Initiate Return:** Process a return with the specific sub-reason "Suspected Counterfeit."

3. **Central QC Routing:** The returned item MUST be routed to a ShopEase Central Quality Check Hub, not back to the seller.
4. **Refund Processing:** Refund the customer immediately upon the logistics partner picking up the return.
5. **Brand Verification:** The Central QC hub will verify the product authenticity. If proven fake, the seller is penalized up to ₹50,000 per violation and suspended.

# 5. Seller Cancellation of Orders

## 5.1 Scenario Definition

An order is cancelled by the seller before dispatch due to being Out of Stock (OOS), a pricing error, or logistical inability to fulfill.

## 5.2 Policy Guidelines

- Sellers are heavily penalized for cancelling orders, as it creates a poor customer experience.
- Customers must be compensated for the inconvenience, especially if they missed a sale event price.

## 5.3 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Automated Refund:** Ensure the 100% refund has been automatically initiated to the source account.
2. **Issue Compensation:** If the customer contacts support regarding a seller cancellation, agents are authorized to issue a **₹100 ShopEase Wallet Credit** or a **10% discount coupon** (max discount ₹500) as an apology for the inconvenience.
3. **Price Match (Exceptions):** If the customer complains they lost a "Deal of the Day" price due to seller cancellation, escalate to Tier 2 to issue a specific coupon allowing them to repurchase the item at the original deal price from a different seller.
4. **Seller Penalty:** The system automatically deducts a "Cancellation Fee" (usually 5% of the order value) from the seller's ledger.

# 6. Item Not As Described (INAD) Disputes

## 6.1 Scenario Definition

The customer receives the item, but it materially differs from the listing description, images, or specifications (e.g., ordered a 256GB phone, received a 128GB phone; ordered a red dress, received blue).

## 6.2 Policy Guidelines

- The seller is entirely responsible for listing accuracy.
- In INAD cases, the seller bears the full cost of reverse shipping and marketplace fees.

### 6.3 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Verify Listing vs. Claim:** Compare the customer's claim (and photos) with the exact SKU specifications on the ShopEase product page.
2. **Approve Return:** If there is a clear discrepancy, approve the return request immediately under "Item Not As Described."
3. **Replacement vs. Refund:** Offer the customer a choice. If they choose replacement, ensure the replacement order is flagged so the seller double-checks the variant before dispatching.

## 7. Warranty Claims for Seller-Fulfilled Products

### 7.1 Scenario Definition

A product develops a defect after the standard ShopEase return window (e.g., 7 or 10 days) has closed, but within the manufacturer's warranty period.

### 7.2 Policy Guidelines

- ShopEase is not responsible for fulfilling warranties. Warranties are fulfilled by the Brand's authorized service centers.
- If the brand denies warranty because the seller is "unauthorized," ShopEase must intervene.

### 7.3 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Within Return Window:** Process a standard return/replacement.
2. **Post-Return Window:** Guide the customer to contact the Brand's authorized service center. Provide the customer with the GST invoice downloaded from their order history, which serves as proof of purchase.
3. **Warranty Denial Dispute:** If the brand refuses service stating the ShopEase seller is unauthorized:
    - Request a written denial letter/email from the brand's service center.
    - Escalate to Tier 2. Tier 2 will force the seller to accept a direct return and process a manual refund to the customer, as listing an item implies standard brand warranty unless explicitly stated otherwise.

## 8. Brand Authorized vs. Unauthorized Sellers

### 8.1 Definitions

- **Authorized Seller (Brand Tag):** Sellers who have provided authorization letters (Brand NOCs) directly from the manufacturer to ShopEase. These listings feature a blue "Brand Authorized" checkmark.
- **Unauthorized/Parallel Importers:** Sellers who buy legitimate goods in bulk and resell them without formal brand tie-ups.

### 8.2 Policy Guidelines

- ShopEase allows unauthorized sellers to sell genuine goods (parallel importing is legal in India), BUT they cannot claim to offer manufacturer warranties if the brand restricts it.

- If a seller lacks brand authorization, they must explicitly state "Seller Warranty Only" on the product page.

### 8.3 Agent Action

If a customer asks about warranty validity before purchase, agents must advise them to purchase from sellers with the "Brand Authorized" badge to guarantee seamless after-sales service from the manufacturer.

## 9. Buyer-Seller Dispute Resolution Mechanism

### 9.1 Scenario Definition

The buyer and the Seller-Fulfilled (SF) seller are in a direct disagreement (e.g., seller claims buyer returned a used item, buyer claims seller sent a damaged item).

### 9.2 Policy Guidelines: ShopEase Protection Guarantee

ShopEase acts as the final arbitrator in any dispute. If an amicable solution cannot be reached, ShopEase will rule based on documentary evidence.

### 9.3 Step-by-Step Escalation Workflow

1. **Tier 1 (Information Gathering):** * Collect all proof from the buyer (photos, unboxing videos).
    - Initiate a "Seller Query" ticket. The seller has 48 hours to respond with their proof (packing videos, QC checks).
2. **Tier 2 (Mediation):**
    - If the seller rejects the buyer's claim, Tier 2 reviews evidence from both sides.
    - If the evidence is inconclusive, ShopEase policy dictates giving the **benefit of the doubt to the buyer** (up to a certain risk threshold based on account history).
3. **Final Resolution (Trust & Safety):**
    - If a high-value dispute (>$100/₹10,000) is completely deadlocked, it escalates to T&S.
    - **T&S may decide to refund the buyer from the ShopEase Protection Fund (taking the loss) while allowing the seller to keep their payout, purely to resolve the deadlock and retain the customer, provided neither party**

**has a history of fraud.**